

Wildcat

MANCHESTER FREE BULLETIN

NO. 6 PASS IT AROUND

OBJECTIVES

1. To report on, analyse and seek solidarity for important struggles amongst our fellow workers, especially in the Greater Manchester area.
2. To encourage independent working class activity outside of the control of the trade unions and in opposition to all political parties.
3. To aim at the revolutionary overthrow of all governments, bosses and leaders by a revolution in which the majority of people, who at the moment are just expected to follow orders, all play an equal part. And we would like to see the creation of a world without the wages/money/market system, where we can all have a say in how things are run, and where production is for human need not profit.

NHS WORKERS FIGHT BACK

Frustration and anger over the insulting and divisive wage offer to Health Service workers (4% for most and 6.4% for some nurses) effectively a reduction in real wages over the year of at least 6-8%, has eventually forced them to overcome the constraints of 'dedication to the service' and 'professionalism' which the government, employers and press have used to keep them in line. Whilst the majority of nurses in the Royal College of Nursing still refuse to join in any strike action with their colleagues they have at least (for the first time) decisively rejected the wage offer on the table.

The other unions in the Health Service are in theory united in a campaign to defeat the employers and the government over this issue. But theory and practice are not the same and the interests of the Unions and the workers themselves don't necessarily coincide.

For instance pickets we spoke to at the Royal in Manchester during the first two one day stoppages explained how separate union meetings had led to different combinations of union members coming out on each occasion, COHSE staying in the first time and NALGO staying in the second time. One lot of technicians who had a different settlement date hadn't joined in at all. Even the two NUPE branches (there's a separate one for ambulancemen) held separate meetings with different results. Whilst pickets understood the difficulties which nurses faced in deciding to strike, there was some resentment that more of them didn't take some kind of action. The third one day strike was officially supported by all the Unions but received patchy support at the Royal (although solid support elsewhere).

Our suggestion that each hospital needed to have joint meetings of all the workers prepared to take action, with directly elected joint 'campaign' committee was generally accepted by most of the pickets we spoke to as 'only sensible', but they lacked the confidence or perhaps experience to be able to push for this and seemed somewhat resigned to Union divisions. A joint shop stewards committee had eventually been formed and this seemed to be the 'best that could be achieved' as far as most of the people we spoke to were concerned.

Elsewhere in the country these same



union divisions have caused serious problems. In Edinburgh there was an initially united display of militancy by the majority of workers at the Royal and City hospitals in both NUPE and COHSE, who went on 'all-out' strike and became a catalyst for action in the area, which was eventually broken by the withdrawal of COHSE members under pressure from their national union.

However, we don't want to paint too gloomy a picture. In many areas unity has been achieved at 'shop floor' level despite the unions.

Perhaps the most significant development in the dispute so far has been the steady build up of solidarity action from workers outside the Health Service. So far this has included miners, water workers, steelworkers, bus workers, firemen and others. This solidarity action is absolutely vital to the success of the struggle but it is clear that it will only grow, and be sustained if health workers themselves go out and talk directly to other workers rather than leaving it all to union officials. This is how hospital workers got action from South Yorkshire miners as early as May 19th. It may take a lot of courage for the inexperienced to do this but the rewards can really be worth it. At the same time Health workers are likely to get more of a response from others, if they are taking militant and resolute action themselves. Solidarity action cannot be seen as an alternative to action by Health workers, the two must go together, which means pressing for an 'all-out' strike at the earliest opportunity.

Another avenue which hasn't yet been explored is the possibility, not simply of 'solidarity' action, but of joint or combined action with other public service workers in

similar situations. An obvious target here are the local authority white collar workers, who for similar reasons have just been offered and rejected a paltry 5% increase.

Those of us working for Local Authorities have a responsibility to raise this possibility wherever we can. We are of course in the same unions (NALGU and NUPE) but a major rebellion of Public Service workers, with all the political overtones that would have, is not something our Union leaders would cherish and we can expect more opposition than help from them if we try to join forces for our mutual benefit.

One option being pushed by the Union is that would be a complete waste of time is 'arbitration'. This would simply buy the employers and government time to weaken and divide the struggle and almost certainly coming up with nothing of value for the workers (as for the railway men and teachers) even if the government were to accept it.

Clearly this limited dispute can be won, but it won't be easy and it won't be by the Health workers alone.

'DUST UP'

In 'Wildcat' No3 we reported on the dispute in Bury over the Councils attempt to dispose of its' refuse service to a private company and cut down on the number of dustmen. That attempt has been thwarted for the time being, but a similar dispute has arisen in Stockport which emphasises the argument we put forward earlier. Basically, 'privatisation' as it is called, is merely one of a number of strategies aimed at cutting expenditure and reducing the workforce.

In Stockport the Council is threatening to sell off the service unless the workers agree to 51 redundancies and increased workloads. Clearly the Tory Council doesn't mind which way it gets its cut-backs, but is hoping that the Unions opposition to 'private' firms generally will make it back down and persuade its members to make sacrifices.

That hasn't worked so far but in another dispute, with Manchester

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University, over disposal of catering services at Owens Park, noises coming from the same union suggests that these sort of tactics might work for the employers, with the Union perhaps claiming a victory against the dreaded 'privatisation', but the workers losing on jobs and conditions. Hopefully the catering workers won't let that happen.

COLLEGES CUT

NATFE the lecturers union sees it as a serious threat and has "taken legal advice" ! Some of the more militant lecturers have recently picketed the Council with placards saying 'Labour - honour your promises'. Pickets we talked to agreed that there wasn't much hope of that. They agreed that it would be necessary to appeal to other Council workers, but were unsure in view of the recent attitude of NALGO members for instance (see 'Wildcat' No5) of what response they might get.

We have reported on five current 'industrial' disputes taking place in the Manchester area, all in the Public Service sector and all part of much larger national disputes or else one in a series of similar disputes taking place right across the country. It is important that these are not seen in isolation, because they and others (such as the rail dispute) are a direct result of government attempts to cut 'public' expenditure and boost the profitability of British industry in the face of a major world recession. Faced with the fact of that recession many workers feel isolated and helpless but we needn't be isolated and helpless.

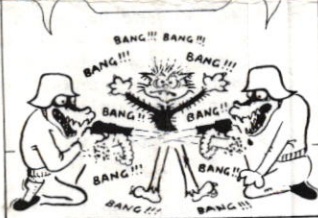
WILDCAT Your wishes are paramount, by me.

Then I wish the pair of you would bugger off.

er... Correction. It's not your wishes, but your **interests** I want to look after.

Thankyou. It's obviously in my interests that the pair of you should bugger off.

No. I'll decide what your best interests are. And if necessary, I'll defend those interests to the last drop of your blood.



We would like to hear from anyone who agrees with our objectives or is interested in the articles we publish. You may be able to give us useful information or write short articles for inclusion in the bulletin. If you like what we produce you could distribute copies of 'Wildcat' regularly at your workplace, school or club etc. We can supply anything from 10 to 100 copies quite easily, free of charge, although financial contributions are most welcome. If your particularly enthusiastic you might actually want to help produce the bulletin.

We can post you single copies of 'Wildcat' as they appear if you send us a £1 contribution (cash or stamps).

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whose side are you on in the Falk-lands war? The daily papers, radio and television are all saying that to oppose the war is to support Argentina. But this is not a war be-tween the British and Argentine peoples. It is a war waged by the ruling class in Britain and Argen-tina against the working class. Who is dying in the Falklands? Predominantly working class soldiers. Who is paying for the war? The work-ing class, who produce the profit the British and Argentine states spend on their armed forces. Who will benefit from the war? Not the Falkland Islanders, not the British or Argentine workers, not the dead soldiers and their families, but the state machines in both countries!

Thatcher's government gladly took up the challenge, telling us we must be prepared to make sacrifices to defend 'democracy' against a 'fascist' dictatorship in Argentina. They conveniently forgot to mention that until this war Britain was supplying arms to that self-same 'fascist' regime, and is now on even more friendly terms than ever with the murderous junta in Chile.

The Labour Party supported the war for the most part, echoing this non-sense about defence of 'democracy'. Those sections of the Labour Party which expressed some opposition could only put forward UN negotiation as their hope for a solution, even though this organisation has been completely discredited as a peacekeeper (viz. Lebanon).

And now Thatcher hopes to use the 'national unity' created by the war to hand out even harsher austerity measures. One way or another we're the ones to pay the bill. Already hundreds have paid with their lives and now we'll be told to accept more financial sacrifices to pay for the weapons in Public sector cuts, tax increases etc.

We have to say quite clearly that this war has not been in our interests at all. Our fight is against the brutal, insane system we live under, East and West, which creates such wars and the class that defends it. The more unity we have as workers the less chance there will be of these wars. We must all realise that we have much more in common with Argentinian workers than with British or Argentinian governments and employers.

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